Chapter 4

React

React has emerged as the most popular of the current JavaScript frameworks. It has a huge user base and a large ecosystem. Structurally, React is the polar opposite of Stimulus. It is more complex and its design reflects fundamentally different assumptions about how best to manage state and logic in a JavaScript program. Specifically, a React application expects to get data from the server and manages state and HTML by managing the DOM on the client using a custom HTML-generation language called JSX.

For our purposes in this book, we will only use a fraction of React's capabilities; our focus here will be on using React to support interactivity on a single page while working with our Rails application. We will not focus on using React for an SPA. An SPA is a perfectly reasonable thing to write in some circumstances, but it is more complex and less likely to benefit from Rails as the back end. We're going to show simpler use cases.

All of this is to say that there are many, many opinions on how to write and structure React apps, and I'm not going to attempt to catalog them all here. This is one way to write React applications for Rails, but it's not meant to be *the* way.